

Book 2 of 5 · Armored Fail Fast · a five-book set

Armored Fail Fast

The Performance Assessment

The rubric is the answer key you're allowed to see.

What this is. How to grade your own rough draft against the rubric on day one, so the first time you learn an aspect is weak is not when the evaluator tells you.

Book	Title	What it does
1	The Pre-Assessment	Fail fast on the practice exam.
2	The Performance Assessment	Fail fast on your own draft, rubric in hand.
3	The Objective Assessment	Take it, see what happens, and mine the coaching report.
4	The Punch List	Every step of all three, as boxes to check.
5	The Adventure Guide	The breadcrumb trail: what each step gives you, and where the whole path leads.

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Six beliefs

Belief	What it means
Recognition is not mastery	Getting a familiar question right proves you have seen it. The real assessment rewords everything.
Fail early, on purpose	The earliest honest measurement is the cheapest. A miss found on day one costs an hour; the same miss found by the grader costs an attempt.
Confidence is data	Mark sure, unsure or guess on everything. Sure-and-wrong is a wrong mental model — the most dangerous result and the first thing to fix.
Principles, not lookups	Fix the rule that produced the miss, then prove it with a reworded or reversed version. Never re-drill the original wording.
Leverage beats weight	Spend time by weight × your gap × how fast the points come — not by weight alone.
Traps are engineered	Every wrong answer, and every weak paragraph, fails in a predictable way. Name the way and it stops working on you.

The seven traps

Every wrong answer on a test, and every weak paragraph on a submission, fails in one of seven ways. Name it and it stops working.

Mold	On a test item	In written work scored by a rubric
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	A required part of the task is missing or only implied.
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	Restates the prompt or the scenario instead of applying it.
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	Meets a neighbouring aspect, not the one being scored.
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect.	Does a lower verb than asked — describes when told to analyze, recommends without justifying.
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	Unsupported certainty; no limits, risks or conditions stated.
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	Uses the wrong framework, model, source or standard for the job.
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	Length, headings or citations that look like the aspect but do not meet it.

The route

1. **Treat the rubric as the answer key you are allowed to see.** Before writing a word, rewrite each aspect as its competent line: the verb · the object · the one element that decides competent.
2. **Draft fast, ugly and complete.** Touch every aspect in the first draft, in rubric order, with a heading per aspect. A complete weak draft can be audited; a perfect half-draft cannot.
3. **Audit with the evaluator's eyes — on day one, not after it comes back.** For each aspect, write where the evidence is (page · paragraph). **No location = not evident.** Don't grade what you meant; grade what is on the page.
4. **Fill the strip for every aspect:** target verb · the one element that decides competent · where it is · self-score (not evident / approaching / competent) · sure / unsure.
5. **Name the mold on every aspect that isn't competent.** The seven molds below, translated for written work. Tally them.
6. **Revise the dangerous ones first:** any aspect you scored competent but can't point to, or were unsure about. Then the not-evident ones. Leave polish for last.
7. **Cold read.** After a night, or read aloud, or hand it to someone with only the rubric. They find what you can no longer see.
8. **STOP before submitting.** Submit only when every aspect has a located piece of evidence and a competent-and-sure mark. One blank location means don't submit yet.
9. **When it comes back,** log each evaluator comment against its aspect and its mold. The comments are the next pre-assessment; the mold tally is the next plan.

The verb decides the aspect

Most returned submissions fail on the verb: they do a lower one than the rubric asks.

The rubric says	It demands	The usual miss
identify / list	Name it. Nothing more is asked.	Explaining at length (wastes time, rarely hurts)
describe	Say what it is or what happened, with the specifics.	Staying generic — no names, numbers or specifics
explain	Say why or how — the cause, the mechanism, the reason.	Describing what without the because
analyze	Break it into parts and show how the parts relate or drive the result.	Describing each part without the relationships
evaluate / assess	Judge it against stated criteria and reach a verdict.	Analysis with no verdict, or a verdict with no criteria
recommend	Choose one course of action and say what to do.	Listing options without choosing
justify / defend	Give the evidence and reasoning that make the choice right, including why not the others.	A recommendation with no support, or support for the wrong choice

Camouflage in a submission

- Length. More words on an aspect is not more evidence for it.
- Headings that name the aspect but sit on top of something else.

- Restating the prompt or the rubric wording back to the evaluator.
- Citations that exist but don't support the specific claim they're attached to.
- Tables and charts that show data without the sentence that says what it means.
- A strong aspect next to a weak one — the evaluator scores each alone.

Worked example — a vendor recommendation memo (invented)

An invented five-aspect rubric and a first draft, audited on day one.

Aspect · verb	Competent means
Needs analysis · analyze	Breaks the business need into requirements and shows which requirement drives the choice.
Option comparison · evaluate	Scores at least two vendors against the same stated criteria and reaches a verdict.
Recommendation · justify	Recommends one vendor and gives the evidence, including why not the runner-up.
Risk · explain	Names the main risk of the choice and explains how it will be reduced.
Sources · identify	Cites the sources for every factual claim in a consistent style.

The audit of the first draft

Aspect	What the draft has	Where	Self-score	Mold	Camouflage to strike
Needs analysis	Two paragraphs describe the company's history and the current system.	p.1 ¶1-2	Not evident	Inverted operation — describes instead of analyzing; no requirement drives anything	Camouflage: 'founded in 2009', '240 employees'
Option comparison	A long table of vendor features.	p.2 table	Approaching	Camouflage — data without the verdict sentence; no stated criteria	The table's length
Recommendation	"Vendor B is clearly the best choice and will guarantee savings."	p.3 ¶1	Approaching	Absolute language — 'guarantee'; no why-not-Vendor-A	'clearly'
Risk	Risk section discusses the project timeline.	p.3 ¶3	Not evident	Adjacent category — schedule risk of the project, not the risk of the vendor choice	Section heading 'Risk'
Sources	Three citations, all in the same style.	p.4	Competent	—	—

What the audit says: two aspects not evident and two approaching — on a draft that looks finished. Fix order: the not-evident ones first, then the verdict sentence, then strike 'guarantee' and add why-not-the-runner-up. Submitting it would have cost a returned submission to learn what one hour of auditing showed.

Rubric self-audit

Fill one row per aspect, from the page — not from memory. **No location = not evident.**

Aspect · target verb	The one element that decides competent	Where it is (page · ¶)	Self-score	Sure?	Mold if not competent
			☐ not evident ☐ approaching ☐ competent	☐ sure ☐ unsure	
			☐ not evident ☐ approaching ☐ competent	☐ sure ☐ unsure	
			☐ not evident ☐ approaching ☐ competent	☐ sure ☐ unsure	
			☐ not evident ☐ approaching ☐ competent	☐ sure ☐ unsure	
			☐ not evident ☐ approaching ☐ competent	☐ sure ☐ unsure	
			☐ not evident ☐ approaching ☐ competent	☐ sure ☐ unsure	
			☐ not evident ☐ approaching ☐ competent	☐ sure ☐ unsure	
			☐ not evident ☐ approaching ☐ competent	☐ sure ☐ unsure	

Triage grid — write each aspect in its box

	Right / competent	Wrong / not competent
Sure	Owned.	Top priority. A wrong model, or evidence you think is there and isn't.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-prove it from the rule.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

Mold	In written work scored by a rubric	Your count
Dropped element	A required part of the task is missing or only implied.	
Wrong stem number	Restates the prompt or the scenario instead of applying it.	
Adjacent category	Meets a neighbouring aspect, not the one being scored.	
Inverted operation	Does a lower verb than asked — describes when told to analyze, recommends without justifying.	
Absolute language	Unsupported certainty; no limits, risks or conditions stated.	
Confusion set	Uses the wrong framework, model, source or standard for the job.	
Camouflage	Length, headings or citations that look like the aspect but do not meet it.	

STOP

Submit only when every aspect has a located piece of evidence and a competent-and-sure mark.

Your own rubric, pre-filled: put its aspects in a rubric file and run **build.py your_rubric.json** — it prints this audit with each aspect's competent line already written.